

Burning Platform vs. Burning Ambition

SLIBRARY 20 · SHEET 3 / 5

Two motives for change

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

This framing contrasts two motives for change — a 'burning platform' driven by threat and a 'burning ambition' driven by opportunity — recognising that change can be powered by fear or by aspiration.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A change-leadership construct, with the burning-platform metaphor popularised in corporate-turnaround discourse and the ambition counterpoint added in later practice.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

It was developed to broaden change motivation beyond crisis, since fear-driven change can be brittle and demoralising.

FIGURE 1 · BURNING PLATFORM VS. BURNING AMBITION



Figure 1. A schematic of the Burning Platform vs. Burning Ambition as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

Leaders choose and communicate the motive — threat, aspiration, or both — that best mobilises the organisation for the change at hand.

WHEN IT IS USED

When framing and launching change and transformation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Change leaders and executives.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It balances threat-driven urgency with opportunity-driven aspiration, offering a more sustainable basis for change.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Kotter's 8 Steps · Slibrary 20

ADKAR Model · Slibrary 20

Transition Curve · Slibrary 20

Change Readiness Radar · Slibrary 20

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Kotter, J.P. (1996) Leading Change. Boston: HBS Press.

Conner, D.R. (1992) Managing at the Speed of Change. New York: Villard.